

GETTING AHEAD

Vargo doesn't tell the characters that they can simply plug themselves into the Six-Face Throne to attune to it (see area 6.28), sharing the power of the cube as equals. The skull lord's much more evil plan is to identify a character or NPC with an Intelligence of 14 or higher, take them to the surgery at area 6.22, get the drop on them—then sever the character's head for grafting onto the skull lord's own shoulders. Vargo's shoulders have room for six heads in total, and the skull lord believes that any newly grafted head will be at least temporarily dominated by its own preexisting personality. The extra head will thus simply serve as an extra brain with which to unlock more powers of the cube.

From the moment Vargo and Bunch (the skull lord's berbalang assistant, who knows of its plan) begin interacting with the characters, both try to assess their intelligence. Bunch uses obvious questions and intelligence tests (see area 6.13), but Vargo is more clever. It might ply the characters with questions about history or scholarly knowledge, or challenge them to games in the library (area 6.29). Vargo focuses on wizards for special attention.

Once it has a fairly good idea which characters are the smartest, the skull lord tries to separate them from their companions. Other characters are allowed to roam the fortress (but not to go out onto the surface), with Vargo hoping that they eventually pixelate. Intelligent characters are attacked, incapacitated (the brain donor must be alive before the procedure), and dragged to the surgery so Vargo can operate.

In the interest of not railroading a character into this fate, Vargo takes an NPC as its first target, starting with Fern or Simak (if the drow's subterfuge of idiocy fails). If the skull lord gains a fourth head, its first action is to make that head start drinking the Styx water that one of its own heads must drink to counter the pixelating curse. As a result, it regains its full skull lord statistics (see area 6.31). The skull lord also becomes visibly taller, though this has no immediate game effect.

If the new head is an NPC, Vargo automatically succeeds at crushing its personality and turning it into nothing more than spare memory storage for the skull lord's dominant brains. If the new head is a character, give the character's player a chance for the head to retain its sense of self by succeeding on two out of three consecutive Charisma contests against Vargo. If the character succeeds, the player retains the ability to speak, think, and occasionally control Vargo's body by winning Charisma contests as you determine.

Only a *wish* spell can restore a character whose head has been grafted onto the skull lord. As Vargo adds more heads, its personality becomes more cold and megalomaniacal—even as occasional flashes of the preferences and personalities of the minds it has absorbed come to the fore.

THE SUPER SKULL LORD

If Vargo gains a fifth head, the skull lord continues to grow in stature and power. In addition to becoming taller, its statistics change as follows:

- Its Strength increases to 16. This increases the attack and damage modifiers of its bone staff attack by 1.
- Its Constitution increases to 19. This increases its hit points to 119 (14d8 + 56).

If the skull lord gains a sixth head, it grows even taller and its final statistics change as follows:

- Its Strength increases to 18. This increases the attack and damage modifiers of its bone staff attack by 1.
- Its Constitution increases to 21. This increases its hit points to 133 (14d8 + 70).
- Its Charisma increases to 23. This increases its spell save DC to 19 and its spell attack bonus to +11.

MISSING SHIPS AND TALKING CUBES

The adventure begins in a lawless port city from which the characters set out to the Changing Island, an hour away by ship. The assumed setting is the Sea of Swords, but you can modify the adventure to start out in any chaotic port city in Faerûn or another campaign world.

STARTING POINTS

Any of the following locations make a good start to the adventure in a Forgotten Realms campaign.

Waterdeep. The greatest city of the Sword Coast features numerous guilds, magical orders, mercantile enterprises, adventuring companies, and criminal organizations that might have an interest in exploring the Changing Island. Alternatively, you might decide to start the adventure off in Skullport. This underground city of criminals, slavers, and evil mages lies beneath Waterdeep, and is part of the great dungeon complex of Undermountain.

Athkatla. “The city of coin” is a huge port city of humans and halflings. With over a hundred thousand inhabitants, the city is the capital of the land of Amn, just south of the Sword Coast. Numerous powerful factions here might already be vying for control of the Changing Island by the time the characters set out to explore it.

Ioma. Home to fewer than a thousand people, Ioma is one of several small pirate ports in the Nelanther Isles, south of the Sea of Swords. The Nelanther pirates are cruel and lawless, and Ioma is ruled with an iron fist by a small group of Cowled Wizards—members of a secret arcane order in Amn.

Port Nyanzaru. The capital of the jungle peninsula of Chult, Port Nyanzaru is detailed in *Tomb of Annihilation*. Though not as lawless and dangerous as some of the other cities in this section, it makes an excellent potential starting point for the adventure.

Ajayib. Sometimes called the City of Wonders, Ajayib is one of the “Pearl Cities”—wealthy seaports on the coast of the desert land of Zakhara, far to the south of the Sword Coast.

Dragonisle. Moving the adventure to the Sea of Fallen Stars, inland and east of the Sword Coast, gives you the option to use Dragonisle as a starting point. The largest of the Pirate Isles, the island is dominated by the eight-thousand-foot-high mountain known as the Earthspur.

Some four thousand pirates dwell here, with most found in the city sometimes known as Immurk's Hold.

FRIENDS AND ALLIES

The setup of the adventure assumes that the characters know people in the port close to where the Changing Island has appeared. But if you're playing the adventure as a one-shot, or if you want to give the characters an additional NPC ally in the area, you can introduce them to Lem—a local **priest** of Kelemvor, Lord of the Dead.

Clad in gray and lawful neutral in alignment, Lem works to prepare dead bodies for burial by bathing them in scented holy water, thus ritually washing away their sins. She gladly offers advice on the afterlife, undead, curses, and similar matters, and can provide *potions of healing* if the characters need them.

When the characters meet with Lem, she confides to them that a few nights earlier, she had a dark dream warning her of evil on the Changing Island. As such, she warns them to be careful on their journey.

THE MYSTERIOUS CHANGING ISLAND

Whatever port the adventurers start out in, they soon hear that a mysterious island has recently appeared in the sea, an hour away by ship. No one has set foot on the island and come back to tell the tale, and sailors have given conflicting descriptions of it, causing it to be nicknamed “the Changing Island.”

The mysterious island was first sighted two weeks before. Since then, the following information has become known to all folk in the port where the adventure begins. Be sure to give the characters this information before they leave port. Establishing the mystery of the Changing Island gives the players a number of vital clues they need before they go there.

- Shortly after the island was first sighted, the sea around it became covered by an unnaturally thick bank of fog. That fog never lifts, leaving the island in a perpetual gray twilight.
- The water around the island is somehow different than the surrounding sea. It is black and silty, offers poor visibility, and feels unnaturally cold. No fish swim in this mysterious black water, which features a clear dividing line from the blue-green sea.
- The island is unnaturally square and about six hundred feet across. A number of hills and valleys can be seen rising beyond the shore, but it's impossible to make out details through the fog.
- A number of explorers have landed ships on the island, but none have returned to tell of what they found. A number of the ships that approached the island have vanished, while others have been found floating with their crews missing. No useful clues have been recovered from these derelict ships.
- “The Changing Island” is so-named because those who pass by it have given a number of conflicting descriptions of it. Some say that the island is nothing but bare stone, featuring terraces of sharp, angular rock in white, red, black, and bronze. Others have talked of the island appearing as a pleasant green atoll of palm trees and plant life, with sandy beaches.

- Most disturbingly, some witnesses have described the island as covered with bodies, as if the place were the site of some terrible battle. A large number of the fallen appeared to be armored soldiers of various races, but most were as naked as the day they were born.

In addition to the well-known lore above, the following information can be discovered by adventurers who research the island while in port. The manner of research is up to you, but might involve Intelligence (Investigation) checks, talking to background contacts, use of the *legend lore* spell, and so forth. Not all the rumors the characters hear will be true. False rumors, or elements of larger rumors that are false, are *italicized* below.

- The island sometimes submerges and rises again. *The crew of one ship saw a giant eyestalk rise out of the water. The island is nothing less than a giant monster!*
- A sailor who fell into the black water was struck dumb in an instant. Even after being hauled out, their mind was like a child's, leaving them not knowing their own name and barely able to speak.
- Monstrous creatures were seen on the island—some sort of two-legged half-dragons with icy white skin and bat wings. They ran to the waterline and howled at the terrified sailors passing by, but didn't take flight to pursue them.
- Not only is the island covered with the dead, *but those dead periodically rise to walk about and reach out to passing ships. There must be thousands of zombies there!*
- A seagull was seen to land on the island to peck at the dead bodies there. It was killed by a tentacle that seemed to grow out of the fog, grabbing the bird and tearing it apart!
- A mighty drow galley was seen in the waters near the island. *Whispered rumors talk of the island as channeling some kind of demonic power, drawing the dark elves from their underground lairs.*
- A mysterious ship carrying those strange shadow-loving folk, the shadar-kai, was seen in the waters near the island.
- *The island is covered with great heaps of glittering jewels!*
- A smoking crater rises at the center of the island. While sailors watched, it blasted out an eruption—not of lava, but of what looked like the bodies of the dead!
- Three days before the island and the black water appeared, a lone fisher reported hearing a great thunderclap and seeing an enormous cube of rock fall from the heavens. Red flames and black smoke followed its passing, as did a shrieking like the voices of a thousand fiends. The fiery cube fell into the sea and disappeared.

RESCUE MISSION

The characters enter the adventure when they are tasked with finding a mage who has vanished while exploring the island. This character might be an old NPC acquaintance of one of the other characters, or

the party could be hired by others who want the mage located and returned.

Sladek is a neutral good genasi **mage** called “Sladek the Blue” for his blue skin and dark blue robes. Local folk know that the mage is fascinated by geology and geography, and that he hired a small boat with six sailors and went to investigate the new island a week before. He and the sailors have not been seen since.

When Sladek ventured onto the island, he was captured by pixelated guards and converted into a pixelated creature. He now serves as Vargo the skull lord’s second-in-command. The sailors were either captured and converted to pixelated creatures or killed by the hydroloths guarding the island, who also tore the ship apart.

If the characters don’t know Sladek, they are hired by the mage’s order to determine what happened to him. Such organizations might include the Watchful Order of Magists and Protectors if the adventure starts in Waterdeep, the Cowled Wizards of Amn if it starts in Ioma, or the Zhentarim in any starting point location.

A servant of the order approaches the characters—Saberhagen, a low-level neutral **diviner** whose green robes match his short, dyed beard. On behalf of his order, Saberhagen offers the characters 5,000 gp each if they can rescue Sladek and return his possessions, or 3,000 gp each to bring back his possessions and his body.

LOUN STONES

Chief among Sladek’s possessions—and a big part of why his order wants those possessions returned—is his collection of six *loun stones*:

- Awareness (dark blue rhomboid): Wielder cannot be surprised
- Insight (incandescent blue sphere): Wisdom increases by 2
- Intellect (scarlet and blue sphere): Intelligence increases by 2
- Mastery (pale green prism): Proficiency bonus increases by 1
- Protection (dusty rose prism): Gain a +1 bonus to AC
- Reserve (vibrant purple prism): Store up to 3 levels of spells

See chapter 7 of the *Dungeon Master’s Guide* for more information on *loun stones*.

When Sladek was pixelated, his *loun stones* were claimed by Vargo the skull lord. Saberhagen gives the characters three *spell scrolls* of *locate object* they can use to track the *loun stones* once they get to the island. When the characters use the scrolls, the position of the stones seems to shift as the skull lord moves around within the cube.

Naturally, if the characters do defeat Vargo and claim the *loun stones*, whether or not to return them for the reward is up to them.

GETTING TO THE ISLAND

When the characters are ready to travel to the island, they can buy a ship, use their own ship if they have one already, or ask Saberhagen to hire a ship for

them. If they ask for sailors who can fight, the ship includes twenty **guards** (neutral mercenaries). The mercenaries take their orders from any character with the soldier background. In the absence of such a character, they follow the orders of the character with the highest Charisma.

MAD MONODRONE

While the characters make their preparations for the journey to the Changing Island, a portside contact introduces them to an odd creature found by fishers in the waters off the island: a spherical, seemingly mechanical being with a single huge eye, and spindly wings and limbs. Any character with experience of planar travel recognizes the creature as a **monodrone**. Recognizing the creature otherwise requires a successful DC 20 Intelligence (Arcana) check.

The only survivor of the modron strike force, the monodrone has lost its connection to Mechanus, and is now a rogue modron stranded on the Material Plane. It knows about the Archquadrone, the yugoloths, the battles that took place on the cube, and the effects of the Styx sea. It doesn’t know about Vargo, Avnas, or any of the recent visitors to the cube (including the drow, the balhannoth, and the shadar-kai).

How much of that information it can tell the characters is another matter, as the monodrone has a toddler’s intelligence and can speak only forty-eight words (see the table below). It cannot count above six, and describes any larger numbers as “six six” or “six six six.” Thankfully, its time on the Material Plane means that the creature has learned to speak those words in Common as well as Modron.

Bad	Good	Soft
Hard	Up	Down
One	Two	Three
Four	Five	Six
Go	Stay	Get
Drop	Give	Put
Boss	Break	Work
Near	Far	Circle
Life	Death	Point
Part	Whole	Lamp
Line	Face	Triangle
Square	Pentagon	Hexagon
Friend	Enemy	Fix
Ear	Resources	Department
Big	Small	Wet
Dry	Eye	Mouth

The monodrone’s mind is so alien that its thoughts cannot be read by magic, and it is immune to being charmed. But it is clearly panicked as it babbles about the “Six Face Bad,” “Bad Square,” and “Bad Boss.” The creature is terrified of the island and doesn’t want to return. However, its need to be part of an order inspires it to instinctively seek a new “boss,” and it quickly latches onto one of the characters in this role. The monodrone becomes a loyal companion and goes wherever its boss goes. However, once it gets to the